Digital Pathshala
by Aaryaman · AI + digital skills for work

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WINDOWS 11 · POWERTOYS · ONENOTE · EXCEL

Copy text from anything on your screen

Screenshots, scanned letters, images, paused videos, locked software — stop retyping. Five free tools already on (or one download away from) your Windows PC, with the exact keys and steps.

Win+Shift+S
then Text actions: copy all text from any snip

Win+Shift+T
PowerToys: drag a box, the text is on your clipboard

25 items
Windows clipboard history (Win+V) keeps your last copies

Every step checked against Microsoft's own documentation

youtube.com/@DigitalPathshalabyAaryaman

Five tools, one job: stop retyping

All of these use OCR (optical character recognition): the computer reads the letters in an image. Pick the tool by what you're copying.

Tool	Best for	Cost	Runs
1 · Snipping Tool — Text actions	Any part of the screen; copy all, select some, or hide emails and phone numbers	Built into Windows 11	On your PC
2 · PowerToys Text Extractor	The fastest: one shortcut, drag, done	Free (Microsoft)	On your PC
3 · PowerToys Advanced Paste	Paste as plain text; turn a copied image into text; optional AI	Free; AI needs a provider	On PC (non-AI)
4 · OneNote	Multi-page printouts: copy text from all pages at once	With OneNote	—
5 · Excel Data from Picture	Tables in an image → real Excel cells	Microsoft 365	Microsoft cloud

Plus one habit: clipboard history

Press `Win` + `V`. The first time, select **Turn on**. Windows then keeps up to **25** copied items (text, HTML, images; up to 4 MB each). Pin the ones you reuse; pinned items survive restarts and "Clear all". Clear everything from `Settings → System → Clipboard`.

Source: Microsoft Support, "Using the clipboard".

Scanned letters & PDFs
Open, zoom so text is sharp, then tool 1 or 2. For many pages, tool 4.

Paused videos
Pause on the frame, then tool 2. Microsoft says Text Extractor works on text in images and videos.

Software that blocks selection
OCR reads the pixels on screen, so tools 1 and 2 still work.

1 Snipping Tool: Text actions

Already on Windows 11. Nothing to install.



1. Press `Win` + `Shift` + `S`, or open Snipping Tool, choose a mode and select **New**.
2. Drag around the text you want. The snip opens in the Snipping Tool window automatically.
3. Select the **Text actions** button. Windows reads the text in the image.
4. Choose **Copy all text**, or select just the words you need and copy them.
5. Paste with `Ctrl` + `V` into Word, Excel, an email or a chat.

HIDDEN EXTRA: QUICK REDACT

In Text actions, **Quick redact** hides email addresses and phone numbers in the snip before you share the screenshot. Useful before you send anyone a screenshot of a form or a chat.

Privacy: Microsoft states that "all text recognition processes are performed locally on your device." Your snip isn't uploaded to read the text.

Tips for clean results

- ✔ Zoom in so the text is large and sharp before snipping.
- ✔ Snip only the text block you need.
- ✔ Always proofread numbers, codes and names after pasting.

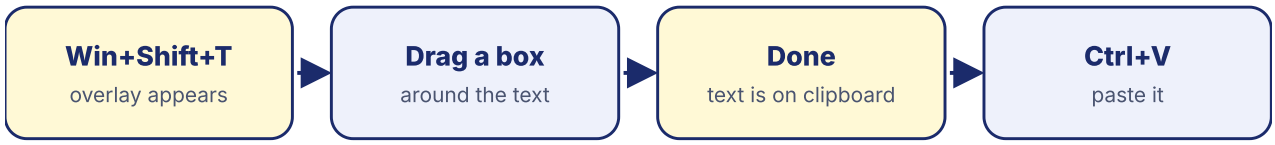
Source: Microsoft Support, "Use Snipping Tool to capture screenshots" (Text actions steps and local processing).

2 PowerToys Text Extractor

The fastest way: one shortcut, drag a box, the text is copied.

Install PowerToys (once)

1. Requirements: Windows 11, or Windows 10 version 2004 (build 19041) or newer, 64-bit (x64 or ARM64).
2. Install from the **Microsoft Store** (aka.ms/getPowertoys) or from **GitHub** (aka.ms/installpowertoys → Assets → PowerToysSetup...exe). Microsoft recommends either.
3. Open **PowerToys Settings** and make sure **Text Extractor** is turned on.



Use it

1. Press `Win` + `Shift` + `T`. A dim overlay covers the screen.
2. Click and drag around the text. Hold `Shift` to move the box instead of resizing it.
3. Let go: the text is copied to your clipboard and the overlay closes. Press `Esc` to cancel.
4. Paste with `Ctrl` + `V`.

Languages

Text Extractor uses Windows' own OCR and recognises only languages whose **OCR language pack** is installed; by default it follows your Windows language. You can change the **Preferred language** in its settings. To see which OCR languages you have, Microsoft gives this command for Windows PowerShell (not PowerShell 7):

```
[Windows.Media.Ocr.OcrEngine, Windows.Foundation, ContentType = WindowsRuntime]
[Windows.Media.Ocr.OcrEngine]::AvailableRecognizerLanguages
```

Sources: Microsoft Learn, "PowerToys Text Extractor" and "Installing PowerToys". Microsoft notes OCR output may be imperfect — proofread it.

3 PowerToys Advanced Paste

Paste the way you want: plain text, Markdown, JSON, or text out of an image.

Copying from a website or PDF often drags fonts, colours and links along with it. Advanced Paste fixes that, and can also turn a copied **image** into text.

Action	What it does	Default shortcut
Open Advanced Paste	Shows all paste options for what's on your clipboard	`Win` + `Shift` + `V`
Paste as plain text	Removes all formatting	`Ctrl` + `Win` + `Alt` + `V`
Image to text	Extracts text from a copied image, using local Windows OCR	Assign one in Settings
Paste as Markdown / JSON	Converts formatted text	Assign one in Settings
Paste as .txt / .html / .png file	Saves the clipboard as a file (e.g. into a folder)	Assign one in Settings

Set it up

1. In PowerToys Settings, turn on **Advanced Paste**.
2. Turn on the actions you want (Image to text, paste as file) and give them shortcuts.
3. Copy something, press `Win` + `Shift` + `V` and pick the action.

RUNS ON YOUR PC

Plain text, Markdown, JSON, paste-as-file, Image to text (OCR) and transcoding all run locally and don't use AI.

PASTE WITH AI IS DIFFERENT

It's **off by default**. Online providers (OpenAI, Azure OpenAI, Mistral, Google...) need an **API key**, may be billed, and receive your clipboard text. Local options (Foundry Local, Ollama, Phi Silica on Copilot+ PCs) keep it on your device.

Source: Microsoft Learn, "PowerToys Advanced Paste". Microsoft doesn't recommend setting Ctrl+V as the activation shortcut.

4 OneNote: copy text from multi-page printouts

For a scanned letter or document with many pages.

1. In OneNote (Microsoft 365, 2024, 2021 or 2016), insert the picture or the file as a printout.
2. **One picture:** right-click it → **Copy Text from Picture**, then paste.
3. **Many pages:** right-click any page image → **Copy Text from All the Pages of the Printout** (or just this page), then paste.
4. If the command doesn't appear, OneNote may still be processing the image; Microsoft notes some results can take 24–48 hours.

Source: Microsoft Support, "Copy text from pictures and file printouts using OCR in OneNote".

5 Excel Data from Picture: tables, not just text

A photo or screenshot of a table becomes real cells.

1. Take a screenshot of the table with `Win` + `Shift` + `S`, or save the image as a file.
2. In Excel: `Data → From Picture → Picture From Clipboard` (or **Picture From File**).
3. Excel shows its progress while it analyses the image.
4. Review the result, correct anything flagged, and click **Insert Data**.

Requirements
Excel for Microsoft 365. On Windows: Windows 11 or Windows 10 version 1903+, and Microsoft Edge WebView2 Runtime.

Better results
Crop to just the table, shoot head-on, in focus. Supported character sets include English; Hindi isn't on Microsoft's list.

PRIVACY

Unlike tools 1–3, this is a Microsoft 365 "connected experience": the image is shared with Microsoft's cloud to process it. Use a local tool for sensitive documents.

Sources: Microsoft Support, "Insert data from picture"; Microsoft Learn, "Connected experiences and your content".

Which tool, and how to check the result

You want to copy…	Use
A few lines from any screen, image or video	`Win` + `Shift` + `T` Text Extractor, or `Win` + `Shift` + `S` → Text actions
A screenshot you'll share, without contact details	Snipping Tool → Text actions → **Quick redact**
Web text without its formatting	`Ctrl` + `Win` + `Alt` + `V` paste as plain text
Text out of a copied image	Advanced Paste → Image to text
Many scanned pages	OneNote → Copy Text from All the Pages of the Printout
A table into Excel cells	Excel → Data → From Picture
Several things to paste later	`Win` + `V` clipboard history

Proofread these every time

Numbers
Amounts, account and phone numbers: compare digit by digit with the original.

Look-alike characters
Check for 0/O, 1/l/I and 5/S in codes and IDs.

Line breaks
Columns can merge into one line; fix them before pasting into Excel.

Microsoft notes for Text Extractor and OneNote that OCR results may be imperfect and should be reviewed.

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Also free: *PDF Tables into Excel — the Verified Guide · 10 Hidden AI Mistakes · Hidden AI Settings · Let AI Do Your Browser Work*

Sources (checked 12 Nov 2026)

Topic	Source
Snipping Tool	Microsoft Support, "Use Snipping Tool to capture screenshots"
Text Extractor	Microsoft Learn, "PowerToys Text Extractor"
Advanced Paste	Microsoft Learn, "PowerToys Advanced Paste"
Install PowerToys	Microsoft Learn, "Installing PowerToys"
Clipboard history	Microsoft Support, "Using the clipboard"
OneNote	Microsoft Support, "Copy text from pictures and file printouts using OCR in OneNote"
Data from Picture	Microsoft Support, "Insert data from picture"; Microsoft Learn, "Connected experiences and your content"

Share freely with credit. Shortcuts are Microsoft's defaults and can be changed in settings; menus may differ slightly by version.